

Q: The number of ayah in holy quran?

By 'verse' is meant what is known as an 'ayah'. This word, linguistically, has a number of meanings such as Sign or indication, admonition or lesson, miracle, and verse or sentence.

When used in Islamic sciences, it is defined to be a part of the Qur'an composed of sequential letters and words, separate from what is before it and after it, with a beginning and end, occupying a specific place in a specific soorah.

Most of the verse breaks are agreed upon, and some are subject to a difference of opinion. Thus, the scholars of the Qur'aan (to be more precise, the scholars of the qira'aat) were divided with regards to this question into seven opinions. Each city (and therefore each qiraa'a) had its own verse-number.

The scholars of Koofah held the view that there were 6236 verses (and this is the numbering that is present in the mus-hafs written in the qiraa'a of Hafs 'an 'Aasim). The scholars of Basrah considered there to be 6204 verses.

In Damascus, the scholars agreed that the verses were 6227 in number.

Whereas in Hims (Palestine) they held that there were 6232 verses.

In Makkah, 6210 verses were the common opinion.

Whereas in Madeenah the earlier scholars said there were 6217 verses, and the later ones held there to be 6214 verses.

Again, the difference occurs only in where to stop one verse and start another.

What might be one verse for the scholars of Koofah might be considered as two by the scholars of Madeenah, and so on. So, for example, some of the qira'aat consider the last verse of Soorah Faatihah to start from 'Siraat aladheen an'amta'a...' whereas others consider it to start from 'Ghayr il-maghdobi...', thus breaking the last 'verse' into two verses.

Q: The Arrangement of Ayahs and Surahs of the Holy Qur'an

The Arrangement of Ayahs (Verses):

Even though there is a difference of opinion over the actual verse numbering.

There is no difference of opinion over the fact that the arrangement and order of the verses in each soorah is from the Prophet himself. The scholars of Islaam have agreed on this point. Aboo Ja'far ibn Zubayr (d. 807 A.H) said, "The arrangement of the verses in the soorahs in a matter which is from the command of the Prophet and we cannot question it (i.e exercise ijuhaad in it). This is a matter in which there is no difference of opinion among the Muslims"

The Prophet used to mention to the scribe writing the verse where to put the verse in the Quraan. He did not used to do this by his own judgment, for Jibreel used to tell him. And Jibreel was inspired by Allah with this knowledge.

In a narration of Uthmaan ibn Abee al-Aas, it is reported that the Prophet received a revelation and said, “Jibreel came to me and commanded me to put this verse at a certain point in the soorah.”

“Allah commands you with justice” [16:90]

In other words, the Prophet was told not only in which soorah to place the verse but also in which portion of the soorah to do so.

Abdullah ibn az-Zubayr was reading the Qur’aan when he came across this verse, “And those of you who die and leave behind their wives should bequeath for them a year’s maintenance and residence, without turning them out.” [2:240]

He went to Uthmaan ibn Affaan, and asked him, “This verse has been abrogated by the verses after it, so why do you write it?” He answered, “O mu nephew, I will not change anything from its place.” In this narration, Uthmaan signified that he knew the place of the verse, but he was not willing to leave anything out that the Prophet had not ordered him to.

Apart from this proof, the fact that the Prophet used to recite complete soorah in the prayer and to the Companions individually, shows that the arrangement of the verses must have been taught by the Prophet to the Companions. There are reports, for example, that he recited Soorah Sajdah in Fajr, and he recited al –Baqarah, and Aali-Imraan, and Niisaa”, and Araaf, and many more soorah in the prayer, and he recited Soorah Qaaf more than once during the Friday sermons. In addition, the Prophet used to recite the entire Qur’an during the month of Ramadan and this was witnessed by Zayd ibn Thaabit. Therefore, the companions must have heard the various verses put together to form the soorah.

This is why as Snyootee said, “The recitation of the Prophet in front of the gatherings of the Companions proves that the arrangement of the verses is form him, and the Companions could not change the order of the verses from what the Prophet recited. Therefore, the knowledge of the order of the verses is mutaauaatir.” This is reflected in the fact that there is absolutely no known difference if opinion in the arrangement of the verses for each soorah.

The Arrangement of Surahs (Chapters):

The scholars of Islam have agreed (ijmaa') to the fact that it is obligatory to follow the arrangements of the soorahs in the writing of the mus-haf, and that it is recommend (but not obligatory) to follow this arrangement in the recitation of the Qur'aan, whether this recitation occurs during the prayer or outside of it. However, they have disagreed concerning the origin of this arrangement into three opinions.

1) The first opinion states that the arrangement of the soorahs was from the ijtihaad of the Companions. In other words, when Zayd compiled the official mus-haf, he employed his own ijtihaad in the arrangement of the soorahs, and the other Companions agreed to this. This is the opinion of Imaam Maalik(d. 179 A. H.) and Aboo Bakr al-Baaqillaanee (d. 403 A. H.)

The proof that is given for this opinion is the fact that the difference Companions had different arrangements of the soorahs in their respective mus-hafs. For example, „Alee's mus-haf was arranged in chronological order, starting with Soorahs al-Iqra, then al-Muddathir, and so on. Both of mus-hafs of Ubay ibn ka'ab and Ibn Mas'ood started with al-Baqarah, then an-Nisaa, then Aali- „Imraan. These differences, according to the proponents of this opinion, show that the arrangement of the soorahs was not from the Prophet (SM), for had it been so, these Companions would have written their mus-hafs with the proper arrangement of the soorahs.

However, this is the weakest of the three opinions, since the mus-hafs of the Companions were personal and were not meant for others to read. Most of them were in fact incomplete, and such do not constitute any proof. Apart from that, these mus-hafs were written during the lifetime of the Prophet (SM), when the revelation of the Qur'aan had not ever been completed. Therefore, it would not even have been possible for these mus-hafs to have been arranged in the correct order.

2) The second opinion claims that part of the arrangement was done by the Prophet (SM), and part by the ijtihaad of the Companions. The followers of the opinion, however, have disagreed as to how many soorahs were arranged by the Prophet (SM) and how many by the Companions.

The most common opinion amongst those groups is that all the soorahs were arranged by the Prophet (SM) except for Soorahs at-Tawbah and al-Anfaal. As proof, they use the following narration: Ibn Abbaas narrates that he asked „Uthmaan. “Why did you pair al-Anfaal, even though it is from the mathaani with at-Tawbah, which is from the mi'een. And why did you not write the basmalah between them, and put both of them in the tiwaal soorahs”. Uthmaan answered,

“The soorahs used to be revealed to the Prophet (SM),so whenever something was revealed he would call a scribe and tell him, „Put this verse in the soorahs in which such and such is mentioned.” Soorah al-Anfaal was one of first soorahs to be revealed in Madeenah,and Soorahs at-Tawbah was one of the last parts of Quraan, and iits story was similar to it(i.e., Soorahs at-Tawbah resembled Soorah al-Anfaal), so I thought that it was part of it. The Prophet SAAS passed away before I could ask him concerning this issue, so because of this I put the two of these together, and did not write basmalah between them and put them amongst the seven tiwaal soorahs.”

This narration would be a very explicit proof for those who hold the opinion,if it was not for the fact that the above narration is weak. Therefore, this narration cannot be taken as proof in this matter.

This opinion, that all of the Quraan except for Soorahs at-Tawbah and al-Anfaal was arranged by Prophet SAAS, was held by As-Suyoote, (who claimed that this was the opinion of the majority scholars) and al Byhaqee and others.

It should be pointed out that the proponents of both of the above opinions claim that the present arrangement must be followed, since the companions all agreed to it (ijmaa).

3) The last opinion states that the Soorah order was from the command of the Prophet SAAS. In other words, the arrangement of Soorahs was understood by the companions since the Prophet SAAS taught them this, and this is why Uthmaan arranged the soorahs in the present arrangement.

This is perhaps the strongest opinion on the matter. This is because the Prophet SAAS used to Recite the soorah to the companions in a specific order, and he mentioned the order of some of them in certain hadeeth. For example, he said, “Recite the two bright ones: al- Baqarq and Aali imraan, and he said, I have given in place of the Torah the seven tiwaal and I have given in place of the Psalms the mi“een and I have given in place of the Gospel the mathaani and I was honored over others with mufassal. It clearly shows that the Quraan had been arraned into some order by the prophet SASS Also, when the Prophet SAAS recited the Quraanto Jibreel every year, he must have recited it in a particular order and Zayd was present when he recited it. When Othman compiled the mus-hafZayd would have used the same order that he had heard From the Prophet SAAS.another proof is that none the companion objected to this order. Therefore, arrangement of soorahs must have been known to the companions and that is why they agreed to it.(ijmaa”) Perhaps the strongest proof is the narration of Hudhyfah at- Thaqafee in

which he said, I asked the companions (during the life time of Prophet SAAS) „How do you divide the Quraan? They replied, We break into three soorahs, then five, then seven, then nine, then eleven, then thirteen, then the mufassal from Qaaf to the end. ""In other words, the Companions would recite the Qur'aan in a specific order so that they could finish it every week. This narration shows that the arrangement of the soorahs was known to all the companions even during the life of the Prophet (SAAS). Imam Al-karmaanee said, "The arrangement of soorahs is from Allaah, and in the Qur'aan is written in the Lauh al Mahfoodh in this arrangement. It was recited to Jibreel by the Prophet (SAW) in this order every year, and he (SAW) recited it twice the year he died. Aboo Bakr al Anbaaree (d. 328 A.H.) said, "The whole Qur'aan was revealed to the lower heavens, then it was revealed gradually, over a period of twenty or so years. A soorah would be revealed in response to an occurrence, and a verse in response to a happening. Jibreel used to inform the Prophet (SAW) of the arrangement and place of the verses and soorahs, so the arrangement of soorahs is like the arrangement of the verses and words all of it is from Prophet (SAW). Therefore, whoever changes the arrangement of a soorah to a place before or after what it should be has ruined the arrangement of the Qur'aan." Al- Hamad writes, "The proofs given (by the proponents of the second opinion) are not explicit, and the possibility remains that the Companions took this arrangement from the Prophet (SAW), and this is the correct view..." In fact, many of the scholars have discussed the wisdom behind the present arrangement of the soorahs. The majority of tafseers also discuss the relationship between the soorahs. In fact, as Suyooti wrote a multi-volume work solely on this topic, entitled Tanaasiq ad-Durar fi Tanaasub as-Suwar.

Q: The Classification of the Surahs of the Holy Qur'an

The word **soorah** means an enclosure or fencing, such as the walls around a city. It is also used to denote an elevated plan. When applied to Islamic Sciences, it signifies a specific group of verses in the Qur'aan, arranged in a specific manner, enclosing certain verses.

The soorahs of the Qur'aan are grouped into four categories, the tiwaal (long) soorahs, the mi'een (hundred) soorahs, the mathaani (oft-recited) soorahs and the mufassal (dis-jointed) soorahs.

These categories are based on a hadeeth of the Prophet (SAW) in which he said, "I have been given in place of the Torah the seven tiwaal, and I have been given in place of the Psalms the mi'een, and I have been given in place of the Gospel the mathaani, and I was honoured over the others with the mufassal."

1. Tiwāl Surahs (The Long Surahs):

These are the first seven soorahs in the Qur'aan after the Faatihah. Some have added at-Tawbah as included in the tiwaal since there is no basmalah that separates it from Soorah al-Anfaal. They have been called tiwaal because they are the longest soorahs in the Qur'aan.

2. Mi'een Surahs (The Hundred Ayah Surahs):

These are the soorahs that have over or around a hundred verses, hence their name.

3. Mathānī Surahs (The Oft-Repeated Surahs):

These soorahs are the oft-repeated ones since they are recited in prayers more often than the longer one. They occur after mi-een.

4. Mufasssal Surahs (The Disjointed or Segmented Surahs):

These soorahs are called disjointed or broken because of the frequent occurrence of the basmallah. They start, according to the strongest opinion, from Qaaf (or, according to another person, al-Hujuraat) and finish with an-Naas.

As for the particular soorahs that qualify as mi-een and mathaani, there does not appear to be any consensus. Some have said that the mi-een soorahs ends at Soorah Faatir.

This would then imply that tiwaal are the soorahs from al-Baqarah to at-Tawbah; the mi-een from Yoonus to al-Faatir; the mathaani from Ya-Seen to al-Hujurat and the mufasssal from Qaaf to an-Naas . Again, this classification is not agreed upon by the scholars.

Other Classifications

The Quran has also been divided into sections to facilitate reading. These divisions have been adopted to assist the completion of the Quran in a certain number of days. The ones that are more common in the mus-hafs of today are as follows:

1. Manzil (Division into Seven Parts):

The Quran is divided into seven manzils, so that if a person wishes to finish the Quran in one week, he may read one manzil a day.

Most of the companions used to finish the Quran in one week. The narration quoted earlier from Hudhayfah shows this: „, I asked the companions of the Prophet how they used to divide the Quran(for reading purposes). They responded, Three soorahs, then five soorahs, then seven soorahs, then nine soorahs, then eleven soorahs, then thirteen soorahs, then the mufasssal from Qaaf to the end.” In other words, the first day of the week they would recite al-Baqarah, AaliImraan

and an-Nisaa; on the second day, the next five soorahs and so on, so that the recitation of the Quran would be finished weekly.

In the mus-hafs of today, the manzils are different from this narration. This division of the Quran into manzils is not present in most mus-hafs printed in Arab countries.

2. Juz (Division into Thirty Parts):

The Quran is also divided into thirty parts, each of which is called a juz. This is done in order to facilitate its reading in one month. In certain non-Arab countries, this division is called a sipaara.

3. Hizb (Division into Sixty Parts):

The mus-hafs printed in Arab countries are typically divided into hizbs. The Qur'aan is composed of sixty hizbs, and thus every juz contains two hizbs. The beginning of each juz is also the beginning of a hizb, and the middle of a juz is the beginning of another hizb. Each hizb is further divided into quarters called ruba. Thus, each juz contains eight ruba's.

4. Ruku: The mus-hafs printed in the Indian subcontinent are typically divided into **rukus**, each equivalent to one or two paragraphs of text. The **ruku** is accompanied by three numbers. The top number denotes the number of the **ruku** with respect to that particular soorah. The middle number indicates the number of verses in that **ruku**. The bottom number of the ruku with respect to the juz in which it occurs.